VIENNA, AUSTRIA

Kunsthistorisches Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works change the scale of looking, from Bruegel's busy worlds to a queen's almost motionless hands.



The Tower of Babel is too large for its workers; a royal child's dress seems almost to reverse the proportions of the body inside it. Elsewhere, a portrait head is assembled from marine creatures. Scale repeatedly alters what the viewer recognises first.

This selection puts that process beside paintings of crowds and concentrated individual encounters. Bruegel lets an entire social world unfold through small actions. Holbein gives a restrained sitter the same sustained attention. The difference is not between important and incidental detail, but between ways of organising it: a figure can carry a painting alone, or acquire meaning through the many other bodies around it.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/kunsthistorisches-museum

The selection · 20

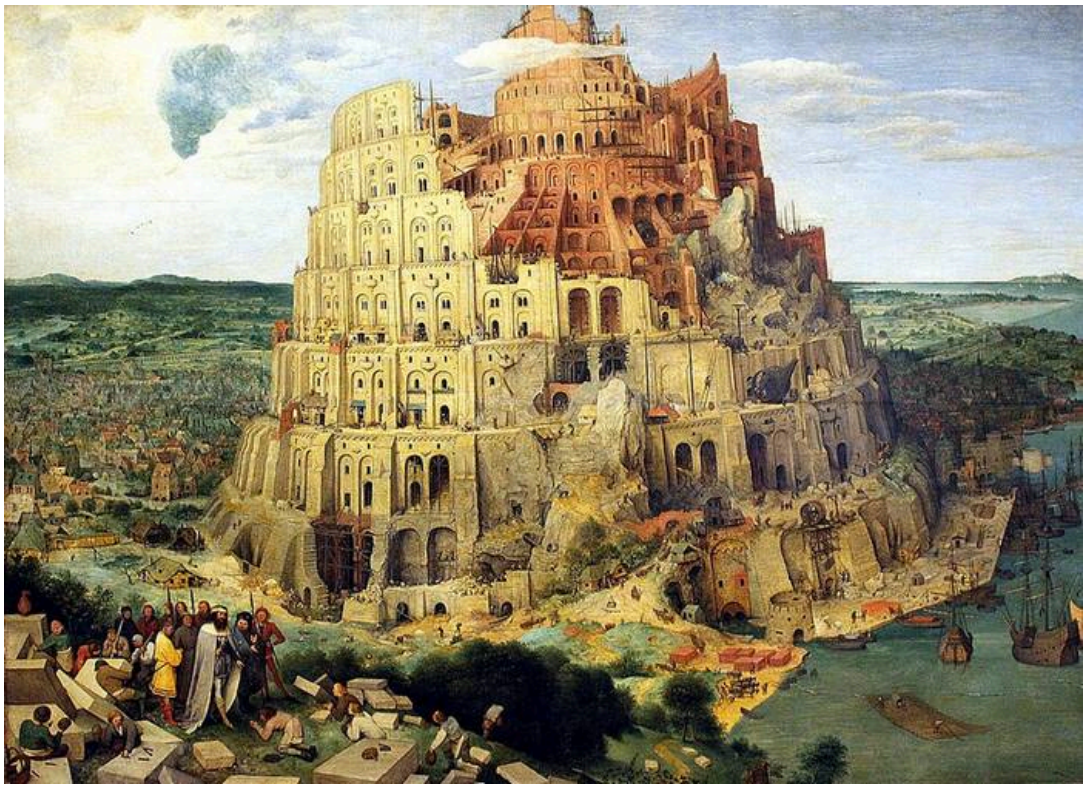
1. The Tower of Babel
   Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1563
2. The Hunters in the Snow
   Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1565
3. The Peasant Wedding
   Pieter Bruegel the Elder · c. 1568
4. The Art of Painting
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1666–1668
5. The Crowning with Thorns
   Caravaggio · 1602
6. The Return of the Herd
   Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1565
7. The Fight Between Carnival and Lent
   Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1559
8. Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror
   Parmigianino · c. 1523–1524
9. The Three Philosophers
   Giorgione · 1505–1509
10. Children's Games
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1560
11. Saint Sebastian
    Andrea Mantegna · c. 1457–1459
12. Jacopo Strada
    Titian · 1567–1568
13. Adoration of the Trinity
    Albrecht Dürer · 1511
14. Jane Seymour
    Hans Holbein the Younger · 1536–1537
15. Hercules and Omphale
    Bartholomeus Spranger · c. 1585
16. Schönbrunn Palace from the Garden
    Bernardo Bellotto · 1758
17. Infanta Margarita Aged Five
    Diego Velázquez · 1656
18. The Peasant Dance
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder · c. 1568
19. Water
    Giuseppe Arcimboldo · 1566
20. Portrait of a Young Woman, Called Laura
    Giorgione · 1506

01 / 20

The Tower of Babel

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1563 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Tower of Babel. Image credit: Dguendel; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Kunsthistorisches_Museum_Wien,_Pieter_Bruegel_d.%C3%84._der_Turmbau_zu_Babel.JPG. CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 4.0

The enormous circular structure dwarfs the workers and visitors who make its scale intelligible. Different stages of construction remain exposed across the walls, complicating its apparent regularity. Bruegel gives the project both monumental ambition and innumerable practical tasks. Moving from the whole tower to its tiny activities changes the image from a single building into a vast accumulation of work.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_1026

02 / 20

The Hunters in the Snow

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1565 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Hunters in the Snow. Image credit: Dudva; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Pieter_Bruegel_the_Elder,_Hunters_in_the_Snow_(Winter).jpg. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 4.0

The hunters and dogs descend from dark, closely placed trees toward a valley busy with skating figures. Their return occupies only one part of winter's wider life. The steep viewpoint permits both bodily fatigue nearby and activity far below to remain visible. Bruegel gives distance its own incidents instead of letting it dissolve into background scenery.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_1838

03 / 20

The Peasant Wedding

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

c. 1568 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Peasant Wedding. Image credit: Yelkrokoyade; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Le_repas_de_noce_Pieter_Brueghel_I%27Ancien.jpg. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 3.0

The bride stays comparatively quiet while servers move food through the crowded barn. Repeated bowls and working hands establish the meal's rhythm. Bruegel makes celebration depend visibly on practical coordination: bodies must carry, bend, receive and eat. The occasion is therefore held together by the labour of feeding people as much as by its ceremonial centre.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_1027

04 / 20

The Art of Painting

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1666–1668 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Johannes Vermeer. The Art of Painting. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The painter's back withholds his face while the curtain gives access to his carefully arranged room. Model, tiled floor, chandelier and wall map occupy measured distances. Vermeer turns the activity of representation into a subject that must itself be represented. The viewer sees a painter looking, but not from the painter's own position.

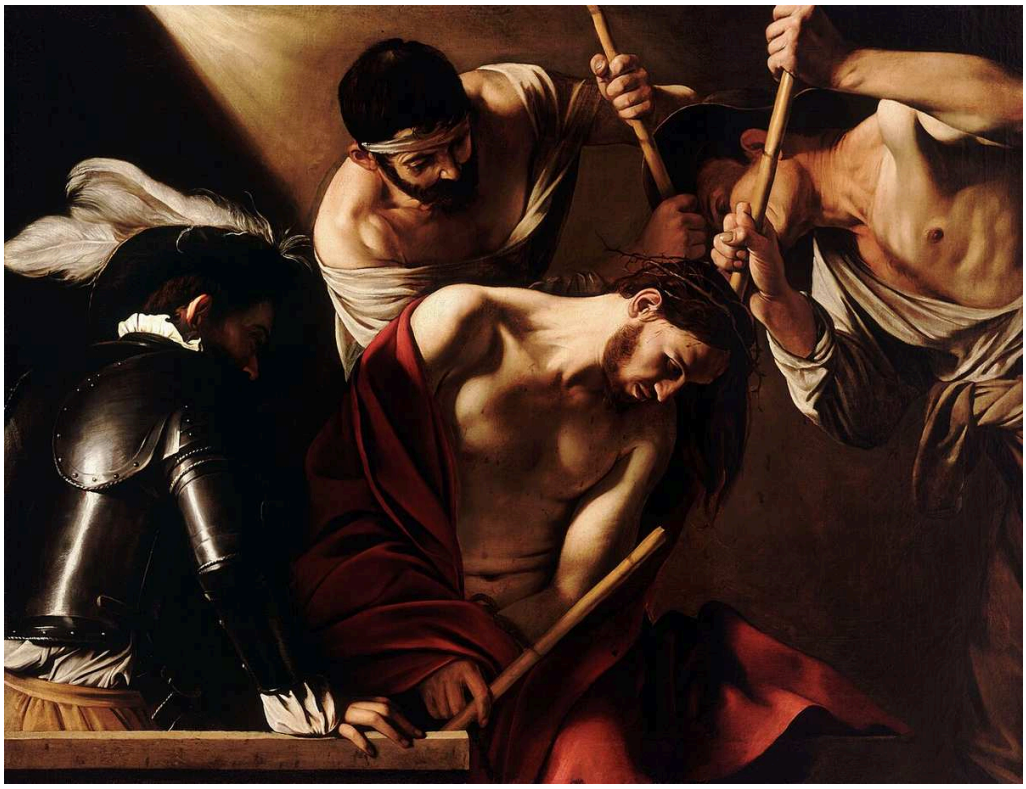
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_9128

05 / 20

The Crowning with Thorns

Caravaggio

1602 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Caravaggio. The Crowning with Thorns. Image credit: Caravaggio. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Rods press toward Christ's bowed head while an armoured figure watches nearby. The contrast between exposed skin and protective metal makes vulnerability unevenly distributed within the close group. Caravaggio leaves little spare distance around the act. The observer's protected body becomes part of its meaning even without sharing the labour of inflicting the violence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_307

06 / 20

The Return of the Herd

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1565 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Return of the Herd. Image credit: Pieter Brueghel the Elder; Own work , Yelkrokoyade , Taken in 13 July 2012, 09:56:21. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:La_rentr%C3%A9e_des_troupeaux_Pieter_Brueghel_l%27Ancien.jpg. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 3.0

The cattle move together across the foreground while hills and water extend well beyond their immediate route. Warm animal bodies separate from the colder distance under a changing sky. Bruegel ties seasonal work to a shared direction of movement. The larger landscape gives that practical task its conditions without reducing it to an incidental decorative procession.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_1018

07 / 20

The Fight Between Carnival and Lent

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1559 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Fight Between Carnival and Lent. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The opposed groups in front belong to a square already full of food, games and smaller encounters. Their contest does not exhaust the town's activity. Bruegel gives rival customs a common environment, allowing surrounding behaviour to complicate the opposition. The painting becomes richer when the eye moves away from its apparent central duel and follows the occupations continuing around it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_1016

08 / 20

Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror

Parmigianino

c. 1523–1524 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Parmigianino. Self-portrait in a Convex Mirror. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The foreground hand expands while the room bends around the circular edge. Parmigianino preserves the convex mirror's distortion instead of correcting it into an ordinary likeness. The face remains recognisable within a space whose proportions depend on an optical device. The portrait shows both a person and the particular conditions under which that person becomes visible.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_286

09 / 20

The Three Philosophers

Giorgione

1505–1509 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Giorgione. The Three Philosophers. Image credit: Giorgione; Yair Haklai Taken in 28 March 2010. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Giorgione-The_Three_Philosophers-Kunsthistorisches_Museum.jpg. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 3.0

Different clothes and positions distinguish the three men, but their relationship does not resolve into one obvious action. The seated figure turns toward the dark rock while a landscape opens beyond. Giorgione gives intervals between bodies and setting unusual importance. The uncertainty is worth retaining; a confident invented conversation would close possibilities the picture leaves available.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_111

10 / 20

Children’s Games

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1560 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. Children's Games. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Running, balancing and grappling occupy successive patches of the town's ground. Each group has its own bodily arrangement, but repetition makes play into an extensive social world. Bruegel allows the scene to be read locally or across the whole surface. Rules become visible through what bodies do together, without a single narrator explaining every game.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Saint Sebastian

Andrea Mantegna

c. 1457–1459 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Andrea Mantegna. Saint Sebastian. Image credit: Andrea Mantegna; anagoria. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:1459_Mantegna_Heiliger_Sebastian_Kunsthistorisches_Museum_Wienanagoria.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Arrows mark pale flesh beside hard classical stone. Mantegna makes the materials differ sharply while repeated verticals hold the bound figure upright. The surrounding ruins introduce another kind of bodily analogy: architecture, too, can be damaged while retaining its form. The landscape beyond offers distance, but the immediate encounter remains between vulnerable skin and carved surfaces.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_301

12 / 20

Jacopo Strada

Titian

1567–1568 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Titian. Portrait of Jacopo Strada. Image credit: Dguendel; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Kunsthistorisches_Museum_Wien,_Tizian,_Jacopo_Strada.JPG. CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 4.0

Strada leans into an encounter with a small sculpture at hand, surrounded by books and collected things. Titian makes handling part of the sitter's public identity. Knowledge and possession are presented through activity, not merely through accessories lined up behind a motionless body. The forward movement gives the crowded environment a human direction.

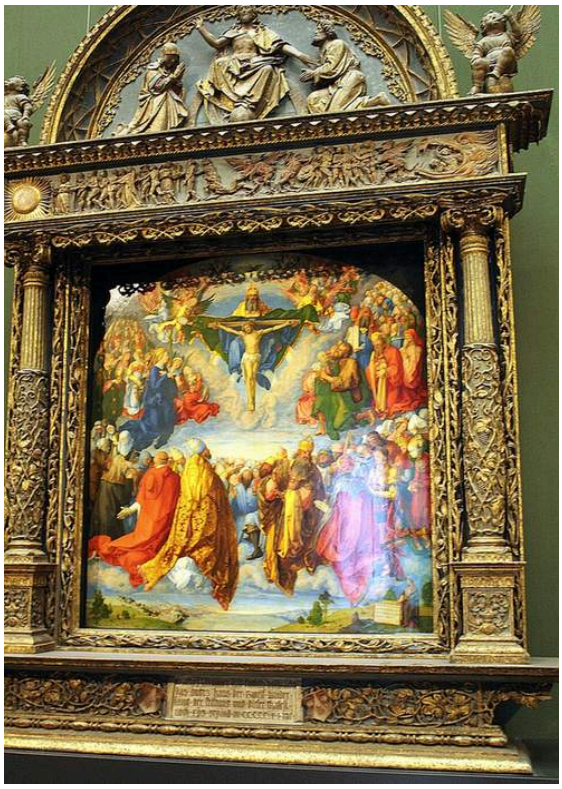
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_81

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Adoration of the Trinity

Albrecht Dürer

1511 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Albrecht Dürer. Adoration of the Trinity. Image credit: Dguendel; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Kunsthistorisches_Museum_Wien,_Albrecht_D%C3%BCrer,_Allerheiligenbild.JPG. CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 4.0

Distinct levels make the large assembly navigable. Heavenly figures establish the upper focus, worshippers gather below, and a narrow landscape supplies a farther earthly register. Dürer gives collective devotion an overall structure without requiring every face to lose its individuality. Broad divisions provide the order within which closer attention can discover separate people.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_838

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Jane Seymour

Hans Holbein the Younger

1536–1537 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Hans Holbein the Younger. Jane Seymour. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Jewellery, fabric and headdress give the queen's rank a precise material form. Her joined hands and restrained face supply comparatively little movement, so small changes acquire greater importance. Holbein makes the costume highly informative without letting it replace the sitter. The portrait holds exact surfaces and controlled human presence in a carefully maintained balance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_881

15 / 20

Hercules and Omphale

Bartholomeus Spranger

c. 1585 · Oil on copper · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Bartholomeus Spranger. Herakles and Omphale. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/bartholomaus-spranger/herakles-and-omphale-1585 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Transferred attributes alter the expected relation between the seated Hercules and the twisting female figure. Spranger makes reversal visible through both objects and pose. The elaborate turns keep the overlapping bodies readable beneath heavy drapery, while their exchanged roles complicate the familiar heroic hierarchy. Myth becomes a means of rearranging who displays which signs of power.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Schönbrunn Palace from the Garden

Bernardo Bellotto

1758 · Oil on canvas · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Bernardo Bellotto. Imperial summer palace of Schönbrunn, garden façade. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/bernardo-bellotto/imperial-summer-palace-of-sch%C3%B6nbrunn-garden-fa%C3%A7ade-1758 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The long façade provides a stable horizontal beyond the formal garden. Small visitors distribute movement across the paths, measuring the building without challenging its dominance. Bellotto's architectural precision accommodates a social setting. The palace remains imposing, but the figures establish how its grounds can be occupied rather than leaving it as a completely uninhabited elevation.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Infanta Margarita Aged Five

Diego Velázquez

1656 · Oil on canvas · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Diego Velázquez. Portrait of the Infanta Margarita Aged Five. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/diego-velazquez/portrait-of-the-infanta-margarita-aged-five-1656 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The dress occupies far more space than the child's exposed head and hands. Its broad geometry makes royal representation a bodily condition she must inhabit. Bright trim and a flower direct attention across the costume, while the small face retains its individual scale. Velázquez shows childhood within the visual apparatus of rank, rather than outside it.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

The Peasant Dance

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

c. 1568 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Peasant Dance. Image credit: Dguendel; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Kunsthistorisches_Museum_Wien,_Pieter_Bruegel_d.%C3%84.,_Bauerntanz.JPG. CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 4.0

Raised feet and swinging arms bring the festival close enough for effort to become visible. The foreground dancers have a weight different from Bruegel's tiny skaters in the winter valley. Their interrupted movements fill the street alongside the bagpiper. Moving nearer changes the account of collective leisure from an extensive pattern into the demands of individual bodies.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GG_1059

19 / 20

Water

Giuseppe Arcimboldo

1566 · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Giuseppe Arcimboldo. Water. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Fish and shells remain identifiable even after they form the profile of a head. Arcimboldo keeps the picture dependent on two incompatible scales of recognition. Concentrating on a creature breaks the face apart; stepping back restores it. The composition works through this repeated alternation, not through a final solution that makes either reading unnecessary.

Object source · Open artwork

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Portrait of a Young Woman, Called Laura

Giorgione

1506 · Oil on canvas · Kunsthistorisches Museum



Portrait of a Young Woman (Laura). WikiArt; Giorgione. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Laurel, fur-lined clothing and pale cloth are described more securely than the sitter's identity can be established. Her turn and the held garment place those surfaces close to exposed skin. Giorgione gives material relations a concentrated presence without supplying a complete biographical account. The conventional name should preserve that uncertainty rather than disguising it as a confirmed identification.

Object source · Open artwork

Move between the whole and one detail

Try this with Babel's workers, a wedding server or one marine creature in *Water*. Returning to the whole should change the detail's role, not make it disappear. The works belong to the museum's collection, but this sequence is not a guaranteed gallery route; confirm current display and access before planning a visit.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s observations on bodies, perspective and light offer ways to examine the arrangements here. They are especially useful beside the portraits and invented architecture, without implying a direct connection to every painter.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12